



BEST PRACTICES FOR FACILITATING A TRAINING VIRTUALLY

Tips for Designing & Facilitating a Virtual Training:

1. **Design materials to still be engaging online**
 - a. Less is more when it comes to designing slides.
 - b. The right visual will always engage learners more than a page of text.
 - c. A snapshot of information is preferred to a detailed resource, which could be emailed after the session.
 - d. Tips: use the chat, collaborative white boarding, and fun memes.
2. **Avoid distractions**
 - a. Participants *and* facilitators should turn off email and phones and limit other distractions as much as possible.
3. **Log in early**
 - a. Facilitators should log in 15-20 minutes before the session starts to test your audio and platform tools. If you are presenting with more than one person, check that there isn't unnecessary feedback coming from the microphones.
4. **Involve the participants**
 - a. Try to involve the participants *every four minutes*. You can use such tools as:
 - i. "Show of hands"
 - ii. The chat box
 - iii. Break out rooms
 - iv. A shared whiteboard
 - v. Polls
 - vi. Quizzes
 - vii. Photo shares
 - viii. Stretch breaks
5. **Set up the participants for post-training success**
 - a. Send out a transcript of questions and answers post-training, as well as copies of any additional readings or resources that were discussed online.
6. **Be more energetic than you would in person**
 - a. Energy is easier to read when you're face-to-face with a group, so facilitators should aim to raise their energy levels.
 - b. Body language is important as well – make sure you are nodding along and showing interest and engagement when others are talking.
7. **Make space for silence in between questions or points**
 - a. Don't rush through the material – take your time.
 - b. Allow space for questions and comments.
8. **Talk naturally**
 - a. Be conversational and include humor.
 - b. Collaborate and interact rather than lecture.

- c. Don't read directly from slides.
- 9. **Practice**
 - a. Practice your materials before hand
 - b. Practice using your platform (putting participants into breakout groups, bringing them back to the main session, uploading documents, sharing your screen, presenting your PowerPoint, pulling up videos, etc.)
- 10. **Encourage feedback**
 - a. Especially in the first few classes, ask participants for their feedback on how things are going, what is working well, and whether they have any suggestions or requests for improving the online training.

How to Engage Participants on Zoom (in no particular order):

1. **Use participant's names** throughout class.
 - a. You can do this when making examples or returning to points that were made or questions that were asked earlier.
2. Engage the participants by **calling on them**.
 - a. Let participants know you will do this from time to time and it's completely all right if they don't know the answer.
3. **Connect and chat with each individual** as they hop on the Zoom call.
 - a. By welcoming participants and asking them how they are doing, you can begin to build relationships and start the class off from a place of conversation and connection.
 - b. Send a private message to any of the participants who join late to welcome them into class.
4. Encourage participants to **use the chat throughout class**.
 - a. Ask them to add their ideas, thoughts, questions or reactions to the chat at any point during the class.
5. Encourage **class-wide discussion and participation**.
 - a. However, always allow participants the option to "pass" if they prefer not to answer or participate at a certain time.
6. Ask the participants to respond with the **participation buttons on Zoom** (raise hand, green check mark, thumbs up, and other emojis).
 - a. For example, you can begin class by asking the participants to share an emoji that best represents their current mood or their day thus far.
 - b. Have participants use the thumbs up or green check to indicate when they've finished an assignment.
7. Encourage participants to use the **"raise hand" feature** if they have a question or comment.
 - a. Keep tabs on who has spoken already so you can call on those who have not yet responded.
8. **Encourage questions throughout the class, not just at the end**.
 - a. If anyone is confused or needs clarification, they should be encouraged to put their question in the chat or raise their hand.

9. **Use the poll and anonymous voting features.**
 - a. This can be a way to engage participants and to gauge how much they are understanding a topic.
10. Use **personal stories and anecdotes** to make class more engaging, fun, and relatable.
11. When using breakout rooms, **visit each group to check-in** and make sure they have something to talk about when you come back to the class-wide discussion.
 - a. Give them plenty of time to share ideas, but also ask for feedback on whether the time in breakout groups is too long or too short.
12. Facilitators should **stay on camera the entire class** and ask participants to keep their cameras on as long as they feel comfortable doing so, as it allows for more engagement and focus for everyone.
 - a. Keeping webcams on allows for more human connection and communication and can allow facilitators to read participants' reactions better.
13. **Schedule breaks** during long sessions so participants can stretch their legs, grab something to eat or drink, use the restroom etc.
 - a. This way they can return to the meeting refreshed and more engaged in the next topics.
14. **Practice good time management.** Facilitators should be aware of the clock throughout class to make sure they will get through the material they planned for or make adjustments.
 - a. Remember that everything takes longer in virtual settings. Factor in extra time for transitioning from breakout rooms to the main session, for example.
 - b. Similarly, if a class-wide or small group discussion is going really well, don't rush it – flex your time and perhaps push something on the agenda to the next class.
15. If participants are comfortable, you can **record each class session** so folks who missed a class can review the content covered that day.
 - a. Ask the participants on the first day if they are comfortable with class being recorded.
16. **Look into your webcam**, not at the participants' faces.
 - a. This will give the closest thing to eye contact you can get when facilitating a training session virtually.
17. **Divide up roles with your co-facilitator.**
 - a. Take turns with your co-facilitator for presenting, navigating the slides, taking attendance, managing the chat box, facilitating breakout rooms, etc.
 - b. When you meet to plan ahead for each class, these roles should be divided up so each session goes smoothly.
18. **Don't be afraid to go analogue.**
 - a. Sometimes using a physical whiteboard, or inviting participants to write things down on paper or in notebooks, can be a nice break from an all-virtual course.



Sources:

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